

Obviously, I was receiving no income from the four wells.

My fluid cash resources—already strained by drilling costs—dwindled rapidly as I paid for leasing the tanks and for trucking my crude several miles from wells to storage.

The situation could have easily turned into financial disaster. I decided to make a frontal attack on one of the biggest of all the major oil companies—Shell Oil. By a fortunate coincidence, Sir George Legh-Jones, then the Shell Company's president, happened to be visiting in Los Angeles. In desperation, I aimed high, asked for an interview with him personally, and was informed that he would be happy to see me during his visit.

A warm, friendly man, Sir George listened attentively to what I had to say. The deepening scowl that etched across his face as he heard me was all the proof I needed that his firm was not a party to the boycott and that he heartily disapproved of such tactics. When I finished talking, he smiled his reassurance.

"Relax," he grinned. "We'll help you."

As a starter, the company would buy the next 1,750,000

barrels of crude oil produced by my Cleaver Lease wells, Sir George told me. In addition, a pipeline would be constructed to link my wells with the Shell Oil Company's pipeline network—and construction work was to commence the very next day.

18

Sir George and the Shell Company were as good as their word. Shell's work crews arrived on my Cleaver site bright and early the following morning and started to lay the pipeline. The boycott was broken—and the Cleaver Lease was safely and profitably mine!

As the 1920s drew to a close, the American petroleum industry began to undergo a radical change. It was rapidly growing more complex; the costs of finding and producing oil were spiraling ever higher. Much greater